



Drupal Module Development

A Quick-Start Practical Guide

In this article, we attempt to build a simple module by learning some basics of the Drupal Module Core. In subsequent articles in this series, we will explore more advanced parts of module development. Since this is a practical guide, we will not delve more into Drupal. This article assumes that the reader has some knowledge of Drupal terminology, Eclipse IDE, as well as basic PHP, including its syntax and the concept of PHP objects. It also assumes a basic understanding of databases (tables, fields, SQL statements, etc), Drupal installation with Web server access, and Drupal administration access.

You can extend Drupal by developing your own modules to suit your application needs. While extending Drupal, you can build upon Drupal Core, and many third party modules are also available.

What is a module?

A module is a collection of files that provides some useful functionality; for example, *Send page/node by Email*, *Show recent blogs*, etc. Modules are the main mechanism for extending Drupal and are written in PHP. The Drupal core executes the module code through 'hooks', which are well-defined interfaces. These 'hooks' are defined by the Drupal interface, and the module must adhere to it so that its code/functionality can be invoked through the Drupal Framework/Engine.

Let us develop a sample module to *Show Recent Blogs*. To do so, let's create a block and main page for this module.

Setting up the environment

Though there are good Linux editors (Emacs, Vim, etc), I find it very convenient to use the Eclipse IDE—for PHP, you can use one from <http://www.eclipse.org/pdt/downloads/>. Download and launch Eclipse, and install the Drupal plug-in as follows: *Help > Install New Software* and use the URL <http://xtnd.us/downloads/eclipse> (click OK if you get any warning message). Create a *New PHP project* (in the wizard, provide a

project name, and specify your Drupal installation folder using "Create project at existing location..."). See Figure 1 for the illustration.

Creating a module

Create a directory named 'recentblogs' in <drupal_install_dir>/sites/all/modules/. This will be your module directory, and we will refer to this as *module_dir* hereafter. Create the main module file 'recentblogs.module' in *module_dir*. Create a block to show recent blogs—add the function below to the *recentblogs.module* file. Observe the naming convention used for the function: it has <module name> as a prefix, and the hook name as per the Drupal API as the suffix, separated by an underscore.

```
function recentblogs_block($op = 'list', $delta = 0, $edit =
array()) {
    // Initialising block contents with empty array
    $block = array();
    if ($op == "list") {
        $block[0]["info"] = t('Recent Blogs');
    }
    else if ($op == 'view') {
        //Placeholder#1
    }

    return $block;
}
```